

Area of Study 1A – Catholic Christianity

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Catholic Christianity as a lived religion in the United Kingdom and throughout the world.

There are four sections: Beliefs and Teachings; Practices; Sources of Wisdom and Authority; Forms of Expression and Ways of Life.

Students will be expected to study Catholic Christianity within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian. Students should compare and contrast the areas of belief and practice within Catholic Christianity with wider Christian perspectives as outlined in the content below.

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.8)*
- The practice and significance of worship (2.2)*.

Students should recognise that Catholic Christianity is one of the many religious traditions in Great Britain which include Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam, Judaism and Sikhism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should also recognise that within Catholic Christianity there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within the wider Christian tradition in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Orthodox, Protestant and other Christian traditions.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs and practices to Catholics today, should be explored throughout the four sections.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The Trinity: the nature and significance of the Trinity as expressed in the Nicene Creed; the nature and significance of the oneness of God; the nature and significance of each of the Persons individually: God as the Father, Son and Holy Spirit; how this is reflected in worship and belief in the life of a Catholic today.
1.2	Biblical understandings of God as a Trinity of Persons: the nature and significance of God as a Trinity of Persons, including reference to the baptism of Jesus (Matthew 3:13–17); the historical development of the doctrine of the Trinity, including reference to the First Council of Nicaea and the First Council of Constantinople.
1.3	Creation: the nature and significance of the biblical account of Creation, including Genesis 1–3; and how it may be understood in divergent ways in Christianity, including reference to literal and metaphorical interpretations; the significance of the Creation account for Catholics in understanding the nature and characteristics of God, especially as Creator, benevolent, omnipotent and eternal.
1.4	The significance of the Creation account in understanding the nature of humanity: the nature and significance of the nature of humanity being created in the image of God, including reference to Genesis 1–3 and divergent understandings of humanity’s relationship with Creation (dominion and stewardship); the implications of these beliefs for Catholics today.
1.5	The Incarnation: Jesus as incarnate Son, the divine Word, both fully God and fully human; the scriptural origins of this belief, including John 1:1–18 and its importance for Catholics today.
1.6	The events in the Paschal Mystery: Catholic teachings about the life, death, resurrection and ascension of Jesus, including reference to Luke 24; the redemptive efficacy of these events and their significance for Catholics today.
1.7	The significance of the life, death, resurrection and ascension of Jesus for Catholic beliefs about salvation and grace, including John 3:10–21 and Acts 4:8–12; the implications and significance of these events for Catholic practice today.
1.8*	Catholic beliefs about eschatology: life after death; the nature of resurrection, judgment, heaven, hell and purgatory, including reference to John 11:17–27 and 2 Corinthians 5:1–10; divergent Christian beliefs about life after death, with reference to purgatory and the nature of resurrection; why belief in life after death is important for Catholics today.

Students should have an understanding of:

2.1	The sacramental nature of reality: Catholic teachings about how the whole of creation manifests the presence of God; the meaning and effects of each of the seven sacraments, including Catechism of the Catholic Church 1210–1211; the practice and symbolism of each sacrament; how sacraments communicate the grace of God; divergent Christian attitudes to sacraments, including reference to Orthodox and Protestant Christianity.
2.2*	Liturgical worship within Catholic Christianity: the nature and significance of the Mass for Catholics, including its structure and the Eucharist as the 'source and summit of Christian life', with reference to Lumen Gentium paragraph 7; divergent Christian attitudes towards the practice and meaning of liturgical worship, including its significance for Catholics and the less structured worship in evangelical Christian denominations.
2.3	The funeral rite as a liturgical celebration of the Church: practices associated with the funeral rite in the home, the church and the cemetery, including reference to 'Preparing my funeral' by Vincent Nichols, Archbishop of Westminster; the aims of the funeral rite, including communion with the deceased; the communion of the community and the proclamation of eternal life to the community and its significance for Catholics.
2.4	Prayer as the 'raising of hearts and minds to God': the nature and significance of different types of prayer; the Lord's Prayer, including Matthew 6:5–14, set (formulaic) prayers and informal (extempore) prayer; when each type might be used and why; the importance of prayer and the importance for Catholics of having different types of worship.
2.5	The role and importance of forms of popular piety: the nature and significance of the Rosary, Eucharistic adoration and Stations of the Cross; how each of these might be used and why; the importance of having different types of worship for Catholics, including reference to Catechism of the Catholic Church 1674–1676; divergent Christian attitudes to these forms of piety.
2.6	Pilgrimage: the nature, history and purpose of Catholic pilgrimage; the significance of the places people go on pilgrimage; divergent Christian understandings about whether pilgrimage is important for Christians today, with specific reference to Jerusalem, Lourdes, Rome, Walsingham and the Catechism of the Catholic Church 2691–2696.
2.7	Catholic Social Teaching: how Catholic Social Teaching reflects the teaching to show love of neighbour; Catholic teaching on justice, peace and reconciliation, Evangelii Gaudium paragraphs 182–237 – The inclusion of the poor in society; how these teachings might be reflected in the lives of individual Catholics, including reference to Matthew 25:31–46 (the Parable of the Sheep and Goats); the work of CAFOD, what it does and why.
2.8	Catholic mission and evangelism: the history and significance of mission and evangelism for Catholics; divergent ways this is put into practice by the Church and individual Catholics locally, nationally and globally, and how this fulfils the commission of Jesus and teachings of the Church, including Evangelii Gaudium Chapter 5.

Students should have an understanding of:

3.1	The development and structure of the Bible as the revealed Word of God: the origins and different literary forms of the Bible. The Old Testament: law, history, prophets, writings. The New Testament: gospels, letters. Divergent Christian understandings about which books should be within the Bible with reference to the Council of Trent.
3.2	Interpretation of the Bible: Catholic interpretation of the Bible and understanding of the meaning of inspiration; divergent interpretations of the authority of the Bible within Christianity: the literal Word of God, the revealed Word of God and as source of guidance and teaching, including 2 Timothy 3:16 and Catechism of the Catholic Church 105–108; the implications of this for Catholics today.
3.3	The magisterium of the Church: the meaning, function and importance of the magisterium both conciliar and pontifical with reference to Catechism of the Catholic Church 100; the magisterium as the living teaching office of the Church and authentic interpreter of the affirmations of Scripture and Tradition, and why they are important for Catholics today.
3.4	The Second Vatican Council: the nature, history and importance of the council; the nature and significance of the four key documents for the Church and for Catholic living: Dei Verbum, Lumen Gentium, Sacrosanctum Concilium and Gaudium et Spes.
3.5	The Church as the Body of Christ and the People of God: the nature and significance of the Church as the Body of Christ and the People of God, including Romans 12:4–6 and 1 Corinthians 12; why the Church as the Body of Christ and the People of God is important for Catholics today; divergent Christian attitudes towards these.
3.6	The meaning of the four marks of the Church: the nature of the Church as one, holy, catholic and apostolic, including reference to the Nicene Creed and the First Council of Constantinople; how the marks may be understood in divergent ways within Christianity; why they are important for Catholics today.
3.7	Mary as a model of the Church: the significance of Mary as a model of the Church – joined with Christ in the work of salvation, as a model of discipleship and as a model of faith and charity, including Luke 1:26–39 and Catechism of the Catholic Church 963–975; the implications of this teaching for Catholic life today.
3.8	Sources of personal and ethical decision making: the example and teaching of Jesus as the authoritative source for moral teaching; Jesus as fulfilment of the Law, including Matthew 5:17–24; divergent understandings of the place and authority of natural law; virtue and the primacy of conscience; the divergent implications of these sources of authority for Christians today.